

POPPing The Cork

E-mail clients aren't all Outlook! There's a whole bunch of them out there—and it's time we did a round-up of the lot

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Despite Instant Messaging, SMS, and other new forms of communication, the *de facto* way of keeping in touch is still e-mail. It was the killer app of the Internet, and its importance has not diminished one bit. In fact, it's the lifeline of many businesses.

The simplest way of checking and sending mail from anywhere is by using Web-based e-mail. In this case, you need to be online and log on to the Web site of your e-mail provider—such as Gmail, Rediffmail, and so on. However, there are times when you can connect to the Internet only once in a while; in such situations, Web-based e-mail solutions cannot be relied upon. Another scenario: you have a company e-mail account, and you're connected to the Internet all the time. Why should you log on to a Web site each time you want to check your mail? It's preferable to just let the mail come into your Inbox as and when it is received. Here is where e-mail clients come in.

When you send an e-mail, it goes to the e-mail server and is stored there. An e-mail client retrieves the mail from the server to the

computer. Not only does an e-mail client let you view your e-mails when you're offline, it also lets you compose mails without having to be connected. Mails composed offline can be sent across once you connect to the internet. This way, if you're on dial-up, or on any other access scheme that makes you pay by the minute, you're better off using an e-mail client than Web mail.

Still, Web mail services offer the convenience of letting you check your mail from anywhere. Many e-mail service providers have revamped their interfaces to mimic that of e-mail clients.

Some of us use both—an e-mail client at work for our office e-mails, if, for example, we aren't allowed to check personal e-mail during work hours—and Web-based mail at home. Ultimately, each method has its pros and cons, and this test is for those who do use an e-mail client—which will be Outlook or Outlook Express in most cases! We wish to remind you that there are alternatives.

We will take a look at twelve of the most popular e-mail clients. These are RimArts Inc.'s Becky! Internet Mail, Qualcomm's Eudora, IncrediMail Xe, MemeCode's i.Scribe, Mulberry, Opera Mail Client, Microsoft Outlook 2003, Microsoft Outlook Express 6.0, Pegasus, Sylpheed, RITLABS S.R.L.'s The Bat! Home Edition, and Mozilla Thunderbird.

